# Building National Progress: The Role of Architecture in Ghana's National Identity

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In the aftermath of World War I (1918) and World War II (1945), the Gold Coast Colony/Ghana experienced profound social and political transformations. These periods of change led to the implementation of architecture as a device for realizing national progress, utilized by both colonial and post-colonial administrations to materialize their visions of national advancement. While Ghana was in a significantly different position from the end of the first World War to the second, there are a number of parallels between how architecture was used as a device by the ruling administrations in the context of institutions of higher education.

Sir Frederick Gordon Guggisberg was appointed Governor of the Gold Coast Colony in 1919, a time when many European powers were reassessing their colonial policies in Africa following the end of World War I. His appointment was part of a broader strategy by the British government to promote development and stability in their African colonies after the war. From the outset of his term, Guggisberg emphasized that education was the cornerstone for the colony's advancement towards a higher state of civilization. This vision materialized with the



Prince of Wales College and School Inauguration, January 28, 1927 [1]

[1] Unknown Photographer, Photograph of the Inauguration of the Prince of Wales College and School, Accra, 1927, Facebook, www.facebook.com/AchimotaSchool

opening of the Prince of Wales College and School on January 28th, 1927. The school was among the largest, most well thought-out, and well equipped of its time in the Colony. However, its curriculum and teaching methods were largely Eurocentric, and consequently the school inflicted significant damage to the preservation of West African culture and tradition while under colonial influence. The Eurocentrism and de-Africanization of the school is perhaps most evident in the architecture of the school's buildings.

The administrative building/main building at the Prince of Wales College and School, is a quintessential example of British colonial architecture in Ghana. The British architect Herbert Baker pulled elements from Georgian, Victorian, and classical British colonial architecture including classical curved arched veranda apertures on the ground level, Victorian balusters on the balcony above the entrance, and typical Georgian windows placed rather symmetrically on the second and third floor. Beyond these individual elements, the general form and stylings of the building adhere closely to British colonial conventions. The choice of a white finish on the majority of the building, a common practice in British colonial architecture in hot climates, serves to reflect sunlight and keep the interior cool. The pitched roofs not only shed rainwater effectively but also provide natural ventilation, a crucial consideration in tropical climates. And the symmetrical layout of the building, a hallmark of British colonial architecture, enhances its grandeur and sense of order. Arguably the most striking feature of the administrative building is its clocktower, which bears a resemblance to the iconic Big Ben in London (and shares the nickname). The clocktower, beyond its practical function of telling the time, symbolizes the authority and permanence of British colonial rule.

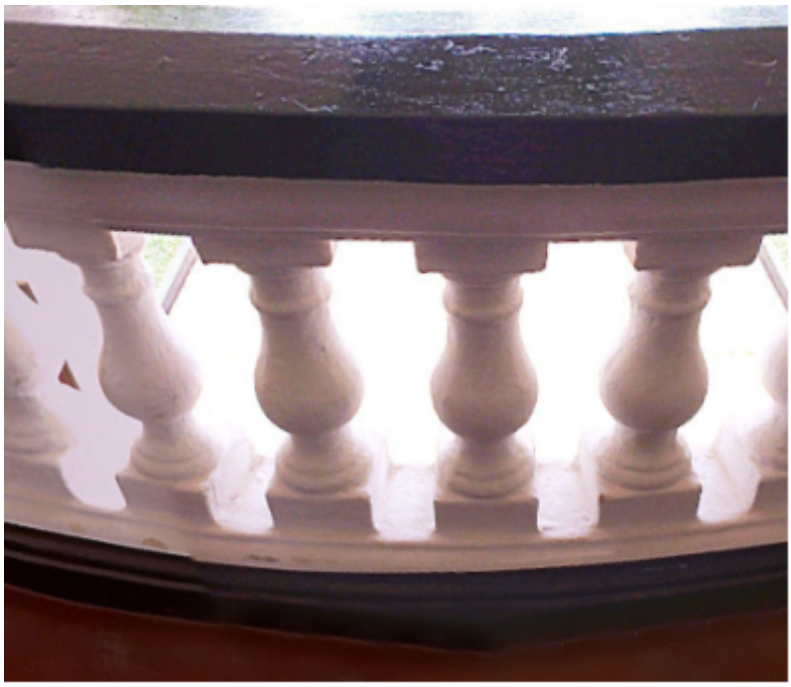


Achimota School in 2018 [2]




Arched Veranda Aperatures and Grand Entrance With Balcony [3]

[2] Kwabena Akuamoah-Boateng, Photograph of Achimota School, Accra, 2016, Google Maps
[3] DOBIISON VR, Photosphere of Achimota School, Accra, year unknown, Google Earth



Victorian Balusters at Entry Balcony [4]

The argument could be made that the British colonial architecture of the Achimota school is a mere reflection of the existing colonial ideologies that were already in place. This argument severely underestimates the colonial leaders' understanding of the significance and impact of architectural choices on cultural identity and heritage. Ghanaian author Robert Addo-Fening described Guggisberg as a leader with a deep interest in architecture, and credited him with initiating and supporting a number of architectural projects in the Colony as he recognized the value of architecture as a tool for development and nation-building in the Gold Coast Colony. The impacts of the implementation of Colonial architecture in the Gold Coast Colony continue to have effects on post-colonial Ghana, influencing how Ghanaians perceive their own cultural heritage and identity. The preservation and reinterpretation of colonial architecture, such as the buildings at Achimota School, presents challenges and opportunities for post-colonial Ghana to

[4] DOBIISON VR, Photosphere of Achimota School, Accra, year unknown, Google Earth

reclaim and redefine its cultural narratives. Therefore, it is essential to recognize the complex intentions of colonial architecture and its impact on cultural identity, rather than dismissing it as a mere reflection of colonial ideologies.

In the aftermath of World War II, the global geopolitical landscape underwent significant shifts, setting the stage for decolonization movements across Africa. The war highlighted the contradictions of colonial rule, as Africans fought for the freedom of European nations while being denied their own. This heightened awareness, coupled with the post-war economic and political challenges faced by Britain, created conditions conducive to Ghana's independence movement. When Ghana gained independence in 1957 the Kwame Nkrumah administration took control. One of Nkrumah's primary goals was to reassert Ghanaian pride and identity, which had been largely eroded by colonialism. To achieve this, he focused on expanding and reforming the education system to reflect Ghanaian history, culture, and values. This involved revising the curriculum to include more content on Ghana's pre-colonial past, traditional beliefs, and cultural practices, while investing heavily in expanding access to education, building new schools, and training teachers. To accommodate this expansion at the Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology, Unity Hall was built to provide additional accommodation for students, particularly those from outside Kumasi, where KNUST is located. By expanding the university's capacity, Unity Hall helped to increase access to higher education for students from all parts of Ghana. Just as the colonial architecture of the Prince of Wales College was implemented to push the colonial agenda, Unity Hall was built with modern architecture designed by Ghanaian architect John Owusu-Addo to push the agenda of the new modern Ghana.



KNUST Unity Hall [5]

Unity Hall at KNUST stands out as a key example of Tropical Modernism, a design approach that integrates modern architectural principles with environmental considerations suitable for tropical climates. John Owusu Addo, incorporated several key features into Unity Hall to address the hot and humid climate of Ghana. One of the hall's defining features is its emphasis on natural ventilation and passive cooling strategies. Large windows and open-air corridors are strategically positioned to allow for cross ventilation, ensuring a constant flow of air throughout the building. This design not only helps to keep the interior spaces cool but also reduces the reliance on mechanical cooling systems, making the building more energy-efficient and environmentally friendly. To protect against the intense tropical sun, Unity Hall features overhanging roofs and shading devices. These elements provide shade and reduce solar heat gain, helping to maintain comfortable indoor temperatures. Additionally, the use of locally sourced materials and traditional construction techniques further connects the building to its

[5] Unknown Photographer, Photograph of KNUST Unity Hall, Kumasi, unknown date

cultural and environmental context. Unity Hall's modern architecture embodies the spirit of post-independence Ghana, symbolizing progress and modernity while also maintaining a strong connection to Ghanaian culture and traditions.

To again counter the argument that the architecture of Unity Hall was simply a reflection of the existing ideologies, it is important to note that Kwame Nkrumah, like Gordon Guggisberg, recognized the transformative power of architecture in shaping national identity and progress. Nkrumah understood that architecture was not just about constructing buildings but about creating symbols of a new, modern Ghana. His administration used architecture as a tool for nation-building, commissioning iconic structures that would serve as beacons of modernity and African identity.

The periods following World War I and World War II marked significant social and political transformations for Ghana. Architecture played a pivotal role in these changes, serving as a tool for both colonial and post-colonial administrations to realize their visions of national progress. Colonial architecture, exemplified by the Prince of Wales College and School, projected European ideologies and eroded indigenous culture/tradition. In contrast, post-independence architecture, such as Unity Hall at KNUST, embraced Tropical Modernism and aimed to symbolize Ghana's new national pride and identity. Both colonial and post-colonial leaders recognized the power of architecture in shaping cultural narratives and used it as a means to advance their goals. As Ghana continues to preserve and reinterpret its architectural heritage, it is crucial to acknowledge the complex intentions behind these structures and their enduring impact on the country's national identity.

# Bibliography

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